Spices lend an extra dimension to many soups and, whether you're using them fresh or dried, they usually require a little straightforward preparation.

preparing spices

bruising whole spices



Before use, whole fresh spices like lemongrass are usually bruised with the blade of a heavy knife and your hand.

grating roots



Roots like ginger can be finely chopped by hand, but it's often easiest to grate them. Peel off the skin beforehand.

seeding chiles



Scraping out the seeds from chiles lessens their heat. Wear a pair of rubber or plastic gloves to do it.

frying in oil



When spices are cooked until lightly colored, their flavor gets trapped in the oil. Use the oil along with the spices.

dry-roasting



To dry-roast spices, place them in an oven preheated to 325˚F (160˚C), or cook them in a dry pan until lightly browned.

crushing



Dried or dry-roasted spices can be crushed by hand in a pestle and mortar or by machine in a spice mill.